



The Past and Future of Scientific Psychology

THE LAST TWO CHAPTERS DEMONSTRATE AN IMPORTANT FEATURE OF the historical development of clinical, social, and developmental psychology in relation to the general development of psychology in America in the 20th century. The development of these subdisciplines of psychology did not simply parallel the general development of psychology in terms of the historical progression from structural to functional psychology, and from behaviorism to cognitive psychology. While theories and therapies based upon behaviorist learning theory and cognitive processing were developed in clinical psychology, they were developed together in the postwar period, which marked the end of the behaviorist hegemony in general psychology. While some social psychologists called themselves behaviorists, they remained committed to the study of social attitudes and public opinion from the beginning to the end of the 20th century. Developmental psychologists never embraced the general commitment by psychologists (including social psychologists) to experimentation as the essence of scientific psychology.

This illustrates the contingency of the development of American psychology. Although one may trace the conceptual continuities and discontinuities between the development of structural and functional psychology, and behaviorism and cognitive psychology, it is well to remember that the development of American psychology depended upon the particularities and peculiarities of the social, cultural, political, and institutional context and the vagaries of the careers of individual psychologists.

This contingency becomes especially apparent when one compares the 20th-century development of American psychology with the development of psychology in other countries (Sexton & Misiak, 1976). To take but a few illustrative examples, Italian psychology embraced cognitive psychology in the early 1920s and never looked back (Mecacci, 1992). When George Miller critiqued the behaviorist position at a talk he gave in London in the 1960s, his host pointed out that there were only three behaviorists in Britain and apologized for the fact that none were in attendance (Baars, 1986). Henri Pieron (1881–1964) articulated the behaviorist

position in France in 1908 (Pieron, 1908), but considered cognitive psychology to be an essential component of experimental psychology (Pieron, 1929).

From its inception, French psychology was closely linked to medicine and clinical psychology, through the work of Charcot, Janet, and George Dumas (1866–1946). The development of psychology in Latin America was based upon a peculiar mix of Wundtian physiological psychology and Freudian psychoanalysis (Stubbe & Ramon, 1997), and Russian psychology prior to the revolution comprised an eclectic mix of cognitive psychology, musicology, psychophysics, physiology, linguistics, and social and development psychology, as well as the objective psychology of Sechenov, Bechterev, and Pavlov (Zinchenko, 1997).

This should remind us that the future of scientific psychology, as much as the past, depends upon the contingencies of historical circumstance and personality.

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